

Ground Rules for Interviewing



It is an art to conduct good interviews that provide relevant insights for value proposition design. Make sure you focus on unearthing what matters to (potential) customers rather than trying to pitch them solutions. Follow these rules to conduct great interviews.

Rule 1

Adopt a beginner's mind

Listen with a "fresh pair of ears" and avoid interpretation. Explore unexpected jobs, pains, and gains in particular.

Rule 2

Listen more than you talk

Your goal is to listen and learn, not to inform, impress, or convince your customer of anything. Avoid wasting time talking about your own beliefs, because it's at the expense of learning about your customer.

Rule 3

Get facts, not opinions

Don't ask, "Would you...?"

Ask, "When is the last time you have...?"

Rule 4

Ask "why" to get real motivations

Ask, "Why do you need to do...?"

Ask, "Why is ___ important to you?"

Ask, "Why is ___ such a pain?"

Rule 5

The goal of customer insight interviews is not selling (even if a sale is involved); it's about learning

Don't ask, "Would you buy our solution?"

Ask "what are your decision criteria when you make a purchase of...?"

Rule 6

Don't mention solutions (i.e., your prototype value proposition) too early

Don't explain, "Our solution does..."

Ask, "What are the most important things you are struggling with?"

Rule 7

Follow up

Get permission to keep your interviewee's contact information to come back for more questions and answers or testing prototypes.

Rule 8

Always open doors at the end

Ask, "Who else should I talk to?"